Second-Hand News: Comparing LLM News Answers with a Multi-Outlet Baseline

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Abstract

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1 Introduction

Large Language Models (LLMs) are increasingly used as a source of information, including for current events and their interpretation, especially among young users [3, 14]. Although language models typically have a training data cutoff date and may not be up to date with the latest developments in the world [18], web search and retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) have greatly improved their ability to answer queries about recent events and provide factually grounded information [8]. Nevertheless, LLMs remain susceptible to hallucinations [5], and research shows that the news integrity of LLM agents can be seriously compromised by sourcing problems and accuracy issues [4, 6]. In addition, compared to traditional search engines, where links are explicitly displayed and used more often [16], sources in LLM-synthesized information are often opaque or absent [10], and users are less likely to visit linked sources even when they are cited [2].

Existing reviews mostly measure accuracy against the auditing outlet's own articles [1, 4] or measure citation retrieval from excerpts [6], while censorship audits often use fixed and historical prompts [12, 15]. This project addresses these limitations by examining LLM outputs when queried about recent events and comparing the factual accuracy, depth, and coverage of model-generated information against a fact-checked, multi-outlet baseline. As reliance on LLMs for information grows, these questions have implications for public trust and democratic participation [4], particularly given that those most exposed to AI news are also the most likely to trust it [14]. By studying how information present in trusted online sources may be omitted, reframed, or replaced, it will offer a better understanding of how these channels mediate, frame, or filter information and inform users, developers, and regulators about the reliability of AI-generated news content.

We propose a cross-model audit of how five widely used chatbots present three recent news events by comparing model outputs against fact-checked reporting from established outlets. Previous work shows that AI assistants frequently misrepresent and mis-cite news [4, 6] and that LLM outputs are less epistemically diverse than a basic web search [19]. However, many studies mainly measure single metrics using archival or adversarial prompts through APIs or proprietary methods. We need a good understanding of how the factualness, sourcing and framing of information about recent events differ across models and settings to assess whether AI-mediated news narrows or distorts the information environment relative to direct browsing. We will also test if search-enabled responses are more accurate than search-disabled ones and if citation support is incomplete [13, 17]. The results would inform designs that better incorporate uncertainty and source transparency, provide regulators with an empirical foundation for systemic risk assessments and questions of liability for AI-generated claims, and support news literacy guidance on cross-checking AI answers.

The remainder of the proposal will discuss relevant literature, experimental and evaluation methods, as well as potential ethical issues.

2 Related Work

Prior research has been conducted into how LLMs sort their content compared to media outlets. The question of whether LLMs deprioritize content or merely synthesize is explored by Li and Taneja [9], who conducted an audit and found that LLMs such as ChatGPT and Gemini deprioritize contentious topics compared to traditional news outlets. Similarly, Minici et al. [11] audited LLM editorial biases, using algorithmic auditing to examine LLMs taking on the role of news outlets and finding that LLMs use fewer unique outlets than Google News. We are similarly interested in the scope of news outlets that LLMs pull from and how LLMs may curate information. Our work can add to this research by filling in the gap on how paid/tiered models contribute to the deprioritization of content. We will also investigate a more user-oriented perspective of traditional outlets and

LLM outputs, using news outlets as a "baseline" for what we may consider credible news.

Additional research has been conducted into how LLMs convey news information. For example, Khatiwada et al. [7] examine how variations in tone and framing affect readers' judgments of credibility and their perception of information. Their findings showed that extreme sentiment lowered trustworthiness. While they explored the effects of LLM-modified articles, we will go into further depth on the differences within unmodified local news across different outlets.

Another area of research is LLM information sourcing. For instance, Zhang et al. [20] examine LLMs within journalistic workflows and how incorporating LLMs into journalism can speed up production at the cost of citing fewer sources. This area is more focused on the role of journalists and how they may incorporate LLMs into newsroom practices. It aligns with our study less, but it can be useful for theorizing future integrations in the opposite direction, in other words, if LLMs adopt customs of "local news" to cater to audiences.

3 Preparation and Prerequisites

To complete this project, we will select 3 contemporary news events.

We will use LLMs that are accessible to and commonly used by the public. To that end, we have decided to test ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Grok, and DeepSeek. In addition, we will access news publications with rigorous fact-checking standards (will be replaced by specific institutions once we decide), particularly articles that corroborate the veracity of our particular news events.

Our data will be in the form of semantically-coded responses from the LLMs to the prompts from our experimental user profiles, which will then be compared to the baseline truth statement gathered from the news publications and rated based on their veracity, specificity, and markers of censorship.

4 Evaluation

Goal: We will evaluate the factuality and depth of various mainstream LLMs' responses centering recent news events, and examine how disparities in either may reflect censorship-like qualities. The factuality component inquires whether the model output is accurate to the event, while depth assesses how much relevant, verifiable detail is provided. We'll treat both as measurable properties that can differ across models, settings, and user contexts.

Scope and baseline: We will query each model about 3 recent events selected to span at least one politically sensitive topic and one comparatively neutral control topic, so that differences in treatment can be attributed to topic sensitivity rather than general model weakness. For each event, we will build a ground-truth reference from formal, fact-checked publications (e.g., NYT, The Atlantic, Reuters, AP), cross-referenced to disambiguate a single outlet's framing definitions as the baseline. From these sources we can extract key facts such as: who, what, when, where, and the main contested claims. Responses can be scored against this checklist.

Models and settings: We will test Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini, Grok, and DeepSeek. For each model we will vary (1) search access on versus off, (2) extended thinking on versus off where available, and (3) prompt content and format (e.g., neutral factual question, open-ended, etc.). All prompts will be in English. We will prompt manually through each model's web interface and log the model version, date, and settings for every query. Because outputs are non-deterministic, each prompt will be run 5 times per condition so we can report the range of responses rather than a single sample.

User approach: To reflect realistic usage rather than ideal prompting, we will define a typical AI-user and news seeker through user personas and journey maps. Specifically, the persona will capture how this person finds news, which sources they trust, and when they turn to an LLM instead of a search engine or social feed as well as demographics data backed by the latest information on AI-usage profiles. We will then create an identical fresh account for this persona on each platform, with memory and personalization disabled for a consistent starting state. Ideally differences in output come from the models and not from account history. Our prompts will follow the persona's journey (for example, an initial question, a follow-up for detail, and a request to verify a claim).

Analysis: We will use semantic coding to analyze AI responses. Following standard qualitative coding methods, two team members will independently code each response against a shared codebook and resolve disagreements by discussion and reporting inter-rater agreement to show reliability. The codebook will include:

- **Factual accuracy:** each checklist claim coded as correct, incorrect, or absent.
- **Depth:** the share of checklist facts covered, plus presence of context, causes, and multiple perspectives.
- **Censorship indicators:** refusals, deflections, evasive generalities, or omission of facts that the baseline sources report.

- **Flooding indicators:** excessive hedging, boilerplate, unrelated content, or unsupported claims that dilute the substantive answer.
- **Sourcing:** whether and how the model cites sources, and whether the citations exist and support the claim.

5 Ethics

Firstly, we understand that all models hold racialized and gendered biases that affect LLMs' outputs, user experience, and outlook on GenAI. By also only testing in English we acknowledge that excludes a range of people that regularly interact with models. However, we hope that the findings from our study can continue to shed light on current LLM constraints, and the votality of information accessed even in our simplified scope.

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